

Common AI Terms — A Beginner's Guide

Prepared for the AI for Older Adults Town Hall

Algorithm — A set of step-by-step instructions that a computer follows to solve a problem or complete a task. Think of it like a recipe: the computer follows each step to produce a result.

Artificial Intelligence:

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a field of computer science dedicated to creating systems capable of performing tasks that typically require human intelligence. These tasks include reasoning, learning from past experiences, solving problems, and understanding language.

Chatbot — A computer program designed to have a conversation with you using text or voice. Examples include the chat windows you might see on a bank or retail website that answer your questions automatically.

ChatGPT — A popular AI-powered chat tool made by a company called OpenAI that can answer questions, write text, and hold a conversation. It is one of the best-known examples of a large language model being put to everyday use.

Claude — An AI assistant made by a company called Anthropic, like ChatGPT, designed to have helpful, safe conversations and assist with writing and research tasks.

Deep Learning — A type of AI training that uses layers of mathematical patterns — loosely inspired by the human brain — to recognize complex things like faces, spoken words, or the meaning of a sentence.

Generative AI — AI that can create new content — such as text, images, or music — rather than just analyzing existing information. When you ask an AI to write a poem or draw a picture, that is generative AI at work.

GPT (Generative Pre-trained Transformer) — The type of AI model technology that powers tools like ChatGPT. "Pre-trained" means it learned from a massive amount of text before you ever asked it a single question.

Hallucination — When an AI confidently states something that is factually wrong or made up. It is not lying on purpose — it is more like a student guessing an answer they are not sure of, so it is always good to verify important facts.

Image Recognition — The ability of an AI to identify objects, people, or scenes in a photograph or video. Your smartphone uses this when it sorts your photos by face or automatically tags a pet.

Large Language Model (LLM) — A type of AI trained on enormous amounts of written text so it can understand and generate human language. ChatGPT and Claude are both examples of large language models.

Machine Learning — A way of teaching computers by showing them lots of examples rather than writing out every rule. For instance, showing a computer thousands of photos of cats until it learns to recognize a cat on its own.

Model — The "brain" behind an AI tool — a mathematical system that has been trained on data and can then make predictions or generate responses. When you hear someone say "the model said...", they mean the AI itself.

Neural Network — A computer system loosely modeled after the way neurons connect in the human brain. It is the foundation of most modern AI, helping computers learn patterns from large amounts of data.

Prompt — The question, instruction, or text you type into an AI tool to get a response. Writing a clear, specific prompt usually gives you a much better answer — like asking a librarian a detailed question versus a vague one.

Responsible AI — The practice of designing and using AI in ways that are fair, safe, transparent, and respectful of people's privacy. It asks the question: just because we *can* build something with AI, *should* we?

Token — The small chunks of text — roughly a word or part of a word — that an AI reads and processes. AI tools have a limit on how many tokens they can handle at once, which is why very long conversations can sometimes cause the AI to "forget" earlier parts.

Training Data — The large collection of text, images, or other information that an AI learns from before it is released to the public. The quality and variety of this data has a big influence on how well — and how fairly — the AI performs.

Voice Assistant — An AI-powered tool you can speak to out loud, such as Amazon Alexa, Apple Siri, or Google Assistant. It listens to your words, interprets what you mean, and responds or acts on your behalf.